relationship defines which identity attributes are needed, how they are used, and how they are protected.

2.3.1 Types of digital relationships

Digital relationships aren't all the same, but they tend to fall into three broad categories:

- *Transactional* relationships center on discrete exchanges—purchasing a product, submitting a form, or completing a contract.
- *Interactional* relationships, which are longer-lived and richer, accumulate history and context as interactions unfold over time—like the relationship you have with your healthcare provider or employer.
- *Exploitative* relationships, where the service derives value directly from the person's identity and behavior—often without explicit consent or clear boundaries—are common in advertising-driven business models.

It's important to recognize that these are not rigid categories. Relationships often blend these characteristics— a transactional purchase may evolve into an interactional relationship over time. Alternatively, an ostensibly interactional relationship may have exploitative elements hidden beneath the surface, where user behavior is silently collected, correlated, and monetized. Each digital relationship is unique and context-specific and evolves over time.

A helpful way to visualize the blended nature of relationships is through the Digital Relationship Triangle, shown in Figure 2.1. Each corner represents a pure version of one of these three relationship types. Most real-world relationships land somewhere inside the triangle, combining aspects of all three.